Out of the Shadows

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/35644582.

Rating:
General Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora & Catra (She-Ra), Castaspella & Glimmer (She-Ra), Catra & Lonnie (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Lonnie (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Castaspella (She-Ra), Swift Wind | Spirit, Juliet (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Hunga (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Not Canon Compliant, Alternate Universe - Canon Divergence, Politics, Intrigue, Espionage, Emotions, Angst

Language:
English

Series:
Part 13 of Catra's Coup

Stats:
Published: 2021-12-11 Words: 5,232 Chapters: 1/1

Out of the Shadows

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/35644582.

Rating:
General Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora & Catra (She-Ra), Castaspella & Glimmer (She-Ra), Catra & Lonnie (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Lonnie (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Castaspella (She-Ra), Swift Wind | Spirit, Juliet (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Hunga (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Not Canon Compliant, Alternate Universe - Canon Divergence, Politics, Intrigue, Espionage, Emotions, Angst

Language:
English

Series:
Part 13 of Catra's Coup

Stats:
Published: 2021-12-11 Words: 5,232 Chapters: 1/1

Out of the Shadows

by EmperorNorton150

Summary

An old enemy resurfaces, forcing the Horde and the Princess Alliance to cooperate. But for Catra and Adora, this crisis hits a little too close to home.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

It had been a long time since Adora had last seen a standard Horde assault formation, but she still recognized the pattern. Flyers had descended from the sky, landing in a perfect pentagon around the foothills of Mount Talon, interlocking fields of fire blasting apart all opposition. Deep ruts stood out through the underbrush, snaking forward towards the mountain-fortress, marking where bots and tanks had spearheaded the attack on the main gates. She could see where follow-up sappers had tossed aside the twisted remnants of the massive bronze doors, and smoke still wafted from a dozen places on the mountain slope where defenses had been shattered by Horde firepower. Green-and-black banners fluttered from open windows and porticos, and Horde troopers were escorting lines out of sullen-looking Harpy prisoners.

"There!" she said, pointing. "Head for the command tent, by the entrance."

"Um, are you sure about this Adora?" asked Swift Wind. She could barely hear him over the beating of his wings as they circled above the mountain.

"Of course!" she replied.

"It's just that I *happen* to notice the lots and lots of very large pieces of artillery that *seem* to be tracking us and I can't help but wonder—"

"It'll be fine, don't worry" Adora assured him, patting his shoulder. "That's just standard Horde operating procedure. They won't fire without a direct order."

"Uh-*huh*" muttered her faithful steed, but dove in for a landing.

The halls of Mount Talon were scarred with blast-marks and gouges as the Horde sergeant led Adora through the twisting passageways. Here and there they passed shattered barricades of furniture, or the gaping maws of empty door-frames. Patrolling

squads of Horde troops trotted back and forth, giving Adora strange glances. Finally, they turned a final corner and the corridor opened up in a vast cavern. A stone throne dominated one wall, carvings glittering in the torchlight. Horde soldiers and technicians had appropriated the banquet tables, and dozens of them bustled around, carrying in boxes of scrolls and tracker pads to sort. Adora tapped her fingers together nervously. Being in the middle of the Horde like this awoke too many conflicting emotions in her—

"So *Your Majesty*. How much did Shadow Weaver pay you to betray me?" Catra's voice cut through the background chatter like a knife. She was standing next to the throne, her back to the rest of the hall, her tail flicking back and forth regularly. Two horde soldiers flanked her, using shock-pikes to pin a bedraggled-looking Harpy to the wall.

"I didn't" rasped Queen Hunga, baring her fangs. "I—watch it! That stings! I didn't! It was before your ascension, O Magnificent one."

"Hmmm" said Catra. "Interesting. Start from the beginning."

"She showed up here maybe a month after she escaped from the Fright Zone" said Hunga. Tattered wings rustled again the stone walls. "Said that if I'd support her, she'd reward us generously after she 'took back what was hers.'"

"And you did?"

"Hey, Shadow Weaver's a lot scarier than Hordak!"

"That's fair" conceded Catra with a flick of her ears. "Is she scarier than *me*?"

"Well, I *would* have said so but now that you're standing in front of me with those nasty sticks…..I think I've changed my mind."

"Good answer. Now then, what 'support' did she want from you?"

"Information, mostly. What the Horde was up to, troops movements, promotions, reports on battles—that sort of thing. Some stuff."

"Stuff?" Hunga shrugged.

"Stuff. You know! Equipment. Weapons. Supplies. Some First Ones artifacts that I, uhhh, managed to acquire. I could get you an inventory?"

"That would be nice" agreed Catra. "And a list of the drop sites?"

"And we'll forget this ever happened?" asked Hunga. Catra cocked her head.

"Your tribute will be tripled for the next—hmm, five years. And I'm leaving a company of troops here to keep an eye on you."

"Fine, fine" growled Hunga. "It's a deal."

"I'm *so* glad we had this discussion" purred Catra. "Force Captain Lonnie will take down the information. *Don't* leave anything out." She turned, and her eyes caught Adora's. It had been long enough since the war ended that Adora had forgotten. She'd forgotten what Catra looked like when she was truly angry.

She swept across the room like a thunderstorm, an invisible bow wave of fury pushing aside anything in her path. Her fur seemed to crackle with the energy, but her eyes were frozen chips of ice, and every movement she made was absolutely precise. Almost unconsciously, Adora's hand dropped to the hilt of her sword.

"What" hissed the Generalissimo of the Horde "are *you* doing here?"

"Uhh, hey!" said Adora, waving. "Yeah, so, Glimmer told me about—"

"That Shadow Weaver's been playing me for a fool?" snapped Catra. "That I'm surrounded by traitors and spies?"

"Um. I mean, she didn't put it like that—"

"If you hadn't noticed I'm *rather busy* right now Adora. I don't need your help and I don't have time for games. So if you'll excuse me—"

"I have a message! From Queen Angella!" Adora called out desperately. Catra turned back and raised an eyebrow.

"Fine" she said. "Go ahead."

"When Glimmer told us that Shadow Weaver was behind the attempt to overthrow you, General Juliet decided to do a little investigation too and……we found a spy of our own."

"Oh?" said Catra. The fur on her arms seemed to settle, and she actually *looked* at Adora for the first time. "I guess that makes sense. You guys are probably as big a threat to her as I am." She frowned. "Wait, it wasn't Lieutenant Leaf, was it?"

"I don't….think so? Why?"

"No reason."

"Ummm. Huh. Ok." Adora scratched her head. "Anyways, Angella thought it would be a good idea to start sharing information. With you I mean. Maybe together we can figure out what she's up to." Hesitantly, she held out a data chip. Catra scowled at it.

"I guess that makes sense" repeated Catra, her ears flicking. "Fine." She reached out and snagged the chip, her claws a blur that barely brushed against Adora's fingers. "Thanks" she

muttered. "I'll…….have Entrapta send over everything we've found."

"Great!" said Adora. Catra stared at Adora, head coked to the side, eyes narrowed. "You know, it doesn't take the Protector of Etheria to deliver a data chip."

"Uhhh, yeah…." said Adora. "About that……." Catra raised an eyebrow. "I just…..I wanted to know how you were doing." Catra sighed.

"I'm doing *fine* Adora, ok? I can handle this."

"I know, but I know how you feel about Shadow Weaver and—"

"*Shut up*" hissed Catra. Her claws extended involuntarily and Adora took a step back.

"Sorry!" she said. With a visible effort, Catra brought herself under control.

"Don't talk about her" she snapped. "Adora, I can handle this, and I don't need your help. Give Her Majesty my thanks for the information. I'll be in touch." With that, she turned around and stalked across the room.

Lonnie was next to one of the banquet tables, going through a pile of ledgers with some technicians when Catra found her.

"Here" she said without preamble, tossing the data chip to the other girl. "Bright Moon caught one of her spies—they say this has everything they've learned. Get it to Entrapta and put it into the scanning program, then package up everything we've learned and shoot it off to the Princesses."

"Sure thing boss" said Lonnie, plugging the chip into a tracker pad. "Think there's anything useful on here?" Catra shrugged.

"Who knows. But every little bit helps. Any word from Scorpia?"

"Yeah, we got a flash transmission twenty minutes ago. One of our informants passed us a lead on Force Captain Zayal so she's headed out to the Crimson Wastes to check that out."

"Good, good" said Catra. Her claws drummed a tattoo on the cold granite tabletop. "I need to get back to the Fright Zone before someone burns it down. Once you get this mess sorted out report back to Fort Skull and see if our patrols in the Eastern Hills have turned anything else up."

"Hey. Catra." Lonnie called out as the Generalissimo turned to go. "You know why she's doing this, right?" Catra froze, the tip of her tail twitching.

"Because she's a crazy old witch with an insatiable lust for power who thinks I'm a worthless piece of garbage?" she asked, her tone light. Lonnie snorted.

"Yeah, yeah, everyone knows that. What I meant was, do you know why she's doing it like *this*? Sneakin' around in the dark, bribing client queens and blackmailing Force Captains and trying to arrange a coup with a cat's-paw?"

"No Lonnie, I *don't* know. But why don't you tell me?"

"Because if she walked through the gates of the Fright Zone and tried to take over again, the Horde would side with *you*. Because you're the best leader we've had and most of us know that. That's why she's creepin' around like a coward. Because we've got your back. Just…..try and remember that, ok?"

"I…." Catra took a deep breath. "Thank you for your…..advice…..Force Captain. I'll—I'll try and keep that in mind."

"No problem boss. Happy to help."

The moonlight blazed down on the Valley of the Lost, seeping into the mudbrick of the buildings and the paving-stones of the streets until the whole city felt like an oven. It seemed to have no effect on the crowds, however. Merchants hawked their wares from tents pitched in every open corner, swarms of clerks and servants scurried to and from the workshops and caravansaries that fueled the city's economy, caravans shouldered their way through the twisting maze.

When a trio of Horde troopers appeared at one end of the street and casually took up position, nobody much noticed. The Horde garrison patrolled vigorously, and if the locals found their officiousness annoying, they appreciated a police force that actually investigated crimes. When two more troops drifted out of the crowd at the other end of the block, several of the more astute local residents decided that now might be a good time to seek business elsewhere.

Ten minutes later, a pair of armored personnel carriers came screaming down the street, scattering people in all directions. They slammed to a stop in front of a nondescript building, hatches popped open, and a squad of Horde troopers swarmed out, wielding quarterstaffs and shock-sticks. The barrel of an automatic weapon poked through a window, sending a stream of slugs to bounce off the armor of the APC. In response, a laser turret on the vehicle opened fire, pulverizing the window. Meanwhile, a pair of troops kicked down the door, and the squad poured through.

As this was happening, the house's backdoor popped open, and a reptilian dressed in long, flowing robes ran out. He dashed down the street, presumably hoping to vanish in the crowds. But as he ran there came a *crash* from a neighboring structure, and a pair of pincers punched through the wall to grab him.

"Whoops! Hold your scorpions pal! I'm afraid I need you to come with me." Scorpia shouldered her way through the rubble pile, beaming at her reluctant guest. She chuckled. "Hold your scorpions, do ya get it? Because *I'm* holding *you!* Well, I thought it was funny at least." She tossed him over her shoulder

and trotted back down the street. He snarled something at her, writhing in her iron grip. “Nope, sorry, no can do Force Captain, Wildcat said to collect everyone on the list and—lemme just double-check this right quick—yep! You’re on the list!” A horde trooper poked his head out the open backdoor and saluted.

“Force General Scorpia! We’ve secured the premises! And it looks like he didn’t have time to purge the data on his tracker pad or communicators.”

“Oh! That’s good, isn’t it?” The soldier nodded vigorously. “Wonderful! Get to work doing all the fancy stuff you’re supposed to do then. I’ll get this rascal back to the truck.” Scorpia strolled down the street, whistling. “It’s a lovely day, don’t you think?”

Her captive didn’t answer.

“……..after analyzing the footprints—and thank you Princess Mermista for your assistance with that—we were able to confirm that Sergeant Norris had been the one with the secret transmitter. I and several of my officers conducted a search of his room, and discovered large sums of gold coins and several missing artifacts. When confronted, he made a full confession. Shadow Weaver contacted him over a year ago. He’s been spying on us ever since, as well as passing various pieces of stolen equipment to her.” Juliet bowed in the direction of Queen Angella. “I should have discovered this far sooner. My apologies, Your Majesty.”

“Nonsense” proclaimed the Queen of Bright Moon, her wings rustling softly. “We had no reason to believe that—that *woman* was even still out there. What sort of equipment?”

“Magical paraphernalia Your Majesty. Crystals, potions, enchanted objects—I have an inventory, but I’m afraid I can’t say more than that.” On the other side of War Room table Castaspella stirred.

"Would you like my people to take a look? We might be able to add some context at least." Her knitting needles continued to *click-click-click* as she talked.

"That would be most helpful" said General Juliet. "My thanks."

"Yes, indeed, thank you High Sorceress" added the Queen with a nod at her sister-in-law. "Juliet, what word from our allies in the Horde?" She sighed. "I'm never going to get used to saying that." The commander of the Bright Moon Royal Guard consulted her tracker pad.

"After Force Captain Cyrus's failed coup attempt last week and the revelation that Shadow Weaver was behind it, Generalissimo Catra arrested five Force Captains and sixteen other officers. Since then, she's launched a wide-ranging and intrusive series of investigations across Horde territory. Two District Commanders and twelve lower-ranked officers have been arrested, as well as several local officials. As of yesterday, we received word that Talon Mountain had been occupied and that Queen Hunga had admitted to complicity. Your Majesty, it appears to be a comprehensive purge of the Horde command structure."

"That could get ugly" murmured Angella. "Any sign of it becoming a more general persecution?"

"Not yet Your Majesty" reported Juliet. "Actually, from what our sources in the towns and villages of the borderlands are saying, the reaction among the civilian population has been quite positive. Apparently, several of the more……obnoxious……local officers are among those taken into custody."

"Well, I suppose that's something." Angella rubbed her temples. "As much as I hate to say it, we'll need to continue cooperating with the Horde. They're in a better position to understand exactly *what* she's up to, and the last thing we can afford is for Shadow Weaver to get control of them again.

General, please continue to monitor the situation, and ensure that our defenses are at full alert."

"Of course Your Majesty!"

"Glimmer, Bow please continue your efforts to coordinate with the Horde. Offer them any assistance they need—and make sure *we* know everything they're up to."

"Yes ma'am!" said Bow with a sloppy salute. Angella frowned.

"Where's Adora?"

"She's in the Crystal Castle training again mom." Glimmer spoke up for the first time in the meeting. "I think she was also hoping she could get some answers out of Light Hope."

"Ah, of course. Excellent. Well, I think that concludes today's agenda. We'll meet again tomorrow, or sooner if anyone learns any news." The council meeting broke up in a flurry of footsteps and conversations, until silence returned to the War Room, broken only by the *click-click-click* of Castaspella's knitting needles. Then there was a cough.

"Um, Aunt Casta? Can I talk to you?" She looked up in surprise. Her niece had stayed behind, looking uncharacteristically anxious.

"Of course dear! What is it?" Glimmer flopped into a chair, her hands twisting together in her lap.

"You…..um…..you used to know Shadow Weaver, right?" A chill seemed to fall over the room, and Castaspella put down her half-knitted scarf.

"'Know' is a very strong word" she said, keeping her voice light. "I'm not sure I would go that far. I'm not sure *anyone* ever truly knew her. But, yes, we were……acquainted. Why do you ask?" Glimmer squirmed in her chair, looking uncomfortable.

"It's just……ever since this whole Shadow Weaver thing started……I mean, I *know* that Adora and Catra have this whole history with her……but it's just…..I know she's a threat but…..and now they're acting so *weird* and…..I just don't know……."

"You're worried about them" Castaspella said, cutting into Glimmer's ramble. The younger girl sighed.

"Yeah" she said. "I guess I am. Adora's been training, like, nonstop since we got the news, which is a little freaky but at least I get that. And Catra…..she's acting like she did right after we signed the Treaty. No, worse. She used to be really sarcastic and mean all the time, but now she won't even *talk* to me. And I can't talk to mom or Bow about it because, they just know her as, y'know, the *commander of the Horde*. And I can't talk to Adora because she'll freak out. So….."

"So, I was your last choice?" teased Castaspella. Glimmer winced.

"Sorry" she said. Her aunt patted her shoulder.

"It's alright dear. Talk to me."

"I think I'm just scared" she said after a long pause. "I don't like seeing them this—this jumpy. It makes me nervous. Am I being silly?"

"No. It sounds to *me* like you're worrying about your friends." Glimmer laughed.

"Catra's not my *friend!*" Castaspella raised an eyebrow.

"Oh?" Glimmer blushed and pulled her legs up onto the chair, hugging them.

"I don't know. Maybe. I mean—who knows what that little fuzzball thinks about *anything*."

"Well, friend or not, it sounds like you're worried about her."

"Yeah…." said Glimmer with a sigh. "I just don't get it. Catra *beat* Shadow Weaver! She used to boast about it *all* the time! And now she bites your head off if you even mention her?"

"Hmmmm" said Castaspella. "I've only met the Generalissimo once or twice, but Adora's told me something about what their life was like growing up." She grimaced. "Honestly, I cannot *imagine* a worse guardian for children than Shadow Weaver but…..I wonder……do you know how she escaped? When she was imprisoned in the Fright Zone?" Glimmer blinked at the apparent *non sequitur*.

"No……?"

"Well, I don't *know* either. But, if I'm remembering our intelligence reports correctly, wasn't Catra herself imprisoned briefly shortly afterwards?"

"Aunt Casta! You can't mean—she *hates* Shadow Weaver! Catra would never *help* her!"

"It's not that simple dear" said Castaspella gently. "Back when she was still Light Spinner, Shadow Weaver was your father's teacher. She was the most powerful sorceress of her generation, and my brother was clearly going to be the greatest of *his* generation. I…..was not. And she made it very clear she was not interested in anything less than the very best. I was so, *so* bitter about it at the time but…..I think if she had ever offered to teach me I still would have jumped at the chance. We'll do a lot to please the people whose approval we want, even when it's not rational."

"Catra's always so—so confident about everything" Glimmer whispered. "She always seems so sure about what to do, she's never afraid—it's hard to imagine some old witch manipulating her like that."

"I know that you and your mother don't always get along." Castaspella chuckled. "For that matter, your mother and *I* don't always get along. But I know that she loves you, and that you love her. Try to imagine growing up with Shadow Weaver instead." The sorceress's jaw clenched, and something very ugly flashed deep in her eyes. "She was bad enough as a teacher and superior."

"Oh" said Glimmer quietly. "What can I do to help?" Castaspella hugged her niece.

"There's only so much you *can* do. Just try and be there. They're going to need you when this is over."

"I'll try."

"It looks like the signals are converging right about there!" said Entrapta, waving her tracker pad with one braid, tapping calculations into a computer with her hands, and gesturing at the copse of trees on the edge of the cliff face with the other braid. "Now, we just have to triangulate in on the receiver dish and pull the main encryption module and I *should* be able to—" Lonnie sighed.

"Sergeant?" she said. He gestured, and two Horde troopers gently picked up Entrapta as she trotted forward and placed her back behind their perimeter. She blinked.

"Oh! Yes! Danger! I forgot."

"I noticed" said Lonnie drily. She turned to the liaison officer from the Princess Alliance. "So. Do you think this is it?"

"Well, *something's* there" said Bow with a nod. "Those vines—those are brambleweeds. They wouldn't grow around the trees like that unless someone planted them that way."

"A defense system" murmured Lonnie. "Well, it's probably not the only one." They'd been backtracking the various

signals sent in by Shadow Weaver's collaborators and spies for over two weeks now as they'd rolled up her network, tracing them through half-a-dozen relays and two scramblers. If Entrapta was right this should be the main transmitter and they could finally find out where she was hiding and get this nonsense sorted out. So *of course* there had to be complications.

"All right" she said finally. "Squad Leader! Deploy the 5th Maniple, standard search pattern. Everyone else, hang back." At her command four bots thundered forward, laser-cannons and sensor arrays sweeping across the trees. Thons cracked and snapped off against the metal casing of the machines as they pushed into the grove. Then—blasts of fire ripped through two of the bots, sending a rain of shrapnel shrieking out to shatter against the portable shields the Horde force had erected.

"Stop!" shouted Lonnie, and the survivors ground to a halt. In the background she could hear Entrapta gleefully chattering about data on tensile strength and plasmatic reactions. "What was that?"

"Directed energy mine Force Captain" replied the Squad Leader. "We could use the bots to sweep them but—"

"Darn transmitter's probably rigged to self-destruct if too many of them detonate" agreed Lonnie. "Bleeding stars!" The Bright Moon warrior with the ridiculous heart on his chest stepped forward and bowed.

"Allow me" he said. Before Lonnie could stop him, he'd raised his bow, fired a grappling-hook arrow into one of the towering trees, and swung through the thicket, deftly avoiding any obstacles. From inside the copse came the came the sound of more arrows being fired, then the sounds of machinery shattering and branches cracking. There was another explosion—and then the bedraggled-looking archer with a long scratch down his face poked his head out into the open.

"All clear!" he called. "But mind the brambleweeds."

"Huh!" said Lonnie, striding into the clearing. Chunks of what looked like a pair of automated defensive turrets lay twitching on the ground where they'd been cleaved apart. The tattered remnants of a tripwire system hung limply from tree-limbs. A massive transmitter dish loomed in the center of the grove—and she could see where a bolas arrow had neatly yanked out a self-destruct module before it could activate. "Nice work arrow boy. I guess I see why Adora keeps you around."

"The name is *Bow*" he replied exasperatedly, sheathing his weapons. Lonnie stared at him.

"Is that really any better?"

"Um……" he scratched his chin. "Hmmm. I mean, when you put it that way…..*huh*." Lonnie left him to his thoughts, watching as Entrapta and a team of Horde technicians swarmed over the transmitter, the Princess of Dryl positively squealing with glee as she pulled apart the maintenance hatches.

I just hope this was all worth it she thought.

Fire, black fire, crawling up her nerves, climbing though her bones, blazing through limbs until she could almost hear the keening whine of the magic rippling through her—with a snap, Catra woke up. In bed. Drenched in sweat. Dreaming. Again. And the whine of her com set was still echoing through her bedroom. She took a deep breath, then another, then a third, reminded herself that the communications equipment belonged to *her* and if she tore it to pieces, she'd just be hurting herself, and then climbed out of bed.

"*What is it?*" she rasped, mashing the button with a claw.

"*I'm very sorry to wake you Your Excellency but she just showed up and won't leave unless I called you and I thought*

it must be important and—" Of course the com tech on duty was Kyle. Of course.

"Kyle. *Who* showed up?"

"*Um. Adora?*" Her claws spasmed, gouging deep gashes into the communicator, and she snarled something unintelligible.

"*Your Excellency? Hello?!*" One breath, then another, then a third. She called on all the self-control she'd been forced to develop in the years she'd ruled the Horde, ruthlessly disciplining her body with the same iron will she'd use to subdue a wayward Force Captain. One breath, then another, then a third. Adora was annoying but she wasn't stupid. She wouldn't show in at the Fright Zone at—her eyes flicked to the timepiece, 1:00 in the morning, *Hordak's teeth*—without a good reason.

"Send her up right away" she finally hissed into the receiver, releasing the button without waiting for a response.

The door hissed open and Adora ducked through, looking around with interest. She'd never seen what Catra's private apartments looked like. They were—ordinary enough, she supposed. Luxurious for the Horde but nothing compared to what even a minor palace official would have at Bright Moon. There was a metal table and a pair of plain but serviceable couches. Shelves lined the walls, laden with tracker pads, ledgers, and bits of equipment. To the rear were a couple of doors leading to the rest of the apartment. The only signs of life were the trophies hanging on the wall—a tattered Bright Moon battle-flag, a crossed Salinean saber and a halberd from the Kingdom of Snows, what looked like a framed photograph of Catra, Scorpia, and Entrapta. Moonlight gleamed through the floor-to-ceiling windows, illuminating the room and the *very* grumpy-looking Catra who was perched on one of the couches, glowering—

"What?" grumbled the Generalissimo, her ears flattening. "Why are you staring?" Eyes wide, Adora pointed at her. "What is—oh." She looked down at her nightgown. It was

white, covered in prancing pink, purple, and green unicorns. “Shut up” she muttered, pulling it tight. “It was a war prize—I found it in one of the vaults and it’s the warmest thing I’ve ever—just shut up.”

“Ok” said Adora, settling onto the couch opposite Catra. “It’s very, ummm. It’s very intimidating?” Catra rolled her eyes.

“Adora, why are you here?”

“Oh. Yeah. Um. So. About that—”

“*Adora*”

“We found where Shadow Weaver’s hiding!” she blurted out. “Or—at least where her spies have been reporting to.” Catra’s fur bristled, but her voice remained calm.

“Where?” Silently, Adora handed over a tracker pad. Catra read it. Then, she leaned back and laughed. It was a quiet, almost gentle, laugh, but it still sent a chill down Adora’s spine. “Typical” she murmured. “You know, sometimes I wonder if the universe is out to get me personally, and then sometimes I *know* it is.”

“What? What is it?” Catra shook her head.

“It’s nothing—just ironic that’s all. After all that trouble she got me into—that she ended up on Beast Island anyways. Like I said, typical.” Adora frowned, but didn’t ask any of the questions she was thinking. Instead, she just said

“Well, it’s over now, right? Both of us can send in the troops and put a stop to her for good.” She punched a fist into her palm and grinned. Catra just flicked her ears.

“It’s not that simple princess. Beast Island’s not just a prison, it’s a deathtrap. The whole place is covered in some kind of force field that kills most technology. My ships can’t even get *near* it.”

"Oh" said Adora. "I thought that you would have some kind of way of getting—"

"Nope. Hordak used to just drop people off in automated capsules and forget about them."

"Used to?" Catra flicked her ears.

"I have better use for prisoners than feeding them to monsters. *Which* is what'll happen to anyone we try and send in there to find her."

"How do you think Shadow Weaver got there then?" Catra shrugged.

"Who knows. Maybe that's what she's been using all those First One artifacts she stole for. Or magic. Magic *always* cheats." She muttered the last part under her breath.

"If it's magic—maybe Glimmer and Castaspella can find some way to duplicate what she's done!"

"Yeah, maybe. Eventually? Probably. But I'm not planning on waiting around for months and months while Shadow Weaver thinks up some new plots."

"You're going in alone, aren't you?" Adora said quietly. Catra's bared her fangs in a mirthless smile.

"Somebody's gotta." Adora didn't say anything, just stared out the window at the smoke billowing from the Fright Zone's foundries, the red light of the furnaces illuminating the clouds from below. After a minute Catra spoke again. "We both now that Lonnie would have reported this to me in the morning. Adora. Why. Are. You. Here."

"I want to help." Adora whispered, still looking out the window. Catra's claws dug into the couch. One breath, then another, then a third.

"You think I can't do this without you?" she hissed.

"No" said Adora. "I know you can. I just……I just don't think you should have to." She turned back to Catra. "I left you to face Shadow Weaver alone once before. I don't want to do that again." Catra sat stock still for a long moment, waiting for another surge of rage. It didn't come. She looked at the other girl sitting across her in the dim light, moonlight gleaming on twists of blonde hair. Blue eyes stared at her out of the gloom, her face so *earnest*, so *sincere* that it almost felt like a joke. Usually, it would infuriate her. Instead, she just felt tired.

"Ok" she said. Adora blinked.

"What?"

"*Ok*, you can help me" said Catra. Adora seemed to almost leap out of her seat.

"Really? That's great!"

"Shut up before I change my mind" grumbled Catra.

"Sorry, sorry!" Adora shook her head, sending her ponytail bouncing. "It's just I didn't expect—never mind. Ok. What now?" Catra didn't understand how anyone could have so much energy at 1:00 in the morning and she couldn't understand why she was so excited to be facing Shadow Weaver again. *Her* stomach felt like it was churning acid. But—it made her a feel little better, to have Adora here. She tamped down that thought, determined not to think too hard about it, and rose from the couch to stare out the window, tail lashing as she thought. Then she smiled.

"Where's that stupid flying donkey of yours?"

End Notes

- I HAVE RETURNED! Oh man, this one took forever to write. I have been working on it, on and off, for like three months now. I apologize for the lengthy delay, and for the fact that this one is mostly set-up for the next story, which will HOPEFULLY be done much quicker now that I know we're I'm going. No promises though.

- Queen Hunga and the Harpies are taken from the 1985 show.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!